

The Government Inspector



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF NIKOLAY GOGOL

Nikolay Vasilyevich Gogol was born in 1809 to a Ukrainian family of petty gentry in Poltava province in the Russian Empire. Gogol was brought up by his deeply religious mother and his father, a poet and amateur playwright, who died when Gogol was 15 years old. From 1820 to 1828, Gogol attended school in Nezhin. Afterward, he moved to St. Petersburg, where he unsuccessfully tried to become an actor. Eventually he secured a minor government position and began writing stories about Ukraine, drawing from his own childhood memories and Ukrainian folklore. He published these stories as *Evenings on a Farm Near Dikanka* in 1831, which quickly made him famous. Gogol continued to write short stories, and at this time he met and befriended Alexander Pushkin, a prominent Russian Romantic poet. In 1835, Gogol asked Pushkin for a plot for a five-act comedy. This comedy became *The Government Inspector*, which premiered in 1836. Due to controversy stirred up by the satirical play, Gogol left Russia and afterward resided mainly in Rome. In 1842, Gogol published two of his most well-known works: the short story “The Overcoat” and the acclaimed novel *Dead Souls*. Throughout the following years, Gogol suffered from psychological and religious turmoil. He died on March 4, 1852, in Moscow.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

In Gogol’s time, the role of government inspector was a real one, first instituted in the Russian Empire by Tsar Peter the Great. Government inspectors’ function was to report on corruption and inefficiency in Russia’s eight administrative provinces. However, traveling across Russia’s vast interior took so much time that local officials commonly had plenty of warning before an inspector arrived, just as Gogol depicts in *The Government Inspector*. Gogol’s characters’ concern about rank is also rooted in the reality of the Russian Empire’s bureaucracy. In 1722, Peter the Great established the Table of Ranks, a system of 14 ranks within the civil service. Equivalent ranks existed in the military, clergy, and imperial court as well. The Table of Ranks was supposed to encourage meritocracy in Russia’s government, but the system grew corrupt. Another contemporary political issue that affected *The Government Inspector* was censorship. Under Emperor Nicholas I, a secret-police force called the Third Department was responsible for surveillance and censorship in order to obstruct open criticism of the government. Considering that *The Government Inspector* satirizes bureaucrats and local government officials, Gogol wouldn’t have been able to stage his play if Nicholas I hadn’t

personally intervened. Nicholas I himself attended the play’s premiere at Alexandrinsky Theatre in St. Petersburg in 1836.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

The Romantic poet Alexander Pushkin greatly supported and influenced Gogol’s literary career. Pushkin may have even suggested the central plot of *The Government Inspector* to Gogol. A similar plot to *The Government Inspector* appears in a comedy called *The Visitor from the Capital, or Uproar in a Provincial Town* by the Ukrainian playwright Grigory Fyodorovich Kvitka. Kvitka’s play likewise features a civil servant from St. Petersburg who is mistaken by provincial town officials for a government inspector. Gogol may have known about Kvitka’s play since it was written in 1827, although it wasn’t published until four years after *The Government Inspector*’s premiere. Another 19th-century Russian playwright who wrote satirical comedies about civil servants, bureaucracy, greed, and corruption is Alexander Ostrovsky. In Ostrovsky’s play *The Bankrupt*, a greedy merchant falsely claims bankruptcy, but his clerk manages to steal his assets and marry his daughter. Gogol himself attended a reading of *The Bankrupt* in 1849. In terms of Gogol’s impact on Russian literature, many critics deem Gogol the father of Russian Realism. Gogol wrote during the Romantic period, but his works of satire, humor, and realism significantly influenced the trajectory of Russian literature. Many later Russian writers credit Gogol as a source of inspiration, including the great novelist Fyodor Dostoyevsky.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Government Inspector
- **When Written:** 1835
- **Where Written:** St. Petersburg
- **When Published:** 1836
- **Literary Period:** Romanticism
- **Genre:** Play, Comedy, Satire
- **Setting:** A small, remote, provincial Russian town in the 1830s
- **Climax:** The mayor and other town officials discover that Khlestakov isn’t the government inspector after all, and they despair over their mistake.
- **Antagonist:** The Mayor

EXTRA CREDIT

Revisions. Gogol was disappointed by the first two productions of *The Government Inspector*, which took place in the spring of 1836. He disliked the actors’ “vaudeville” approach to their

performances. In the following years, Gogol reworked parts of the play and published the corrected, definitive version in 1842.

Guest Appearance. In April 1860, the famous Russian writer Fyodor Dostoyevsky was part of a charity performance of *The Government Inspector*. The production raised money for the Society for Aid to Needy Writers and Scholars. Dostoyevsky played the role of the postmaster.



PLOT SUMMARY

The Government Inspector is set in a remote, provincial Russian town in the 1830s. The town's mayor assembles other local officials in his home and announces that an incognito government inspector from St. Petersburg is coming with "secret instructions" to investigate them. The mayor frantically warns the officials to hide evidence of their maladministration before the inspector arrives. The mayor, judge, Warden of Charities, Inspector of Schools, postmaster, and Chief of Police are all guilty of neglecting their duties and abusing their power, so they're desperate not to get caught.

The landowners Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky rush in with dreadful news. Earlier, at the inn, they saw a young government official from St. Petersburg named Khlestakov. They claim that Khlestakov must be the inspector. Having learned that Khlestakov has already been in town for two weeks, the panicked mayor hastily sends the officials away to clean up the town. Then the mayor prepares to meet Khlestakov at the inn, bringing his scratched **sword** with him and anxiously praying that he won't be in trouble for his sins.

In reality, Khlestakov is not the government inspector. He is only a minor clerk. He and his servant Osip have been stuck at the inn in town because Khlestakov gambled his money away while traveling from St. Petersburg to a different province. Having no money for **food**, Khlestakov and Osip are famished, although Khlestakov manages to beg for a meager lunch from the innkeeper. When the mayor arrives at the inn, Khlestakov fears he's being sent to jail for not paying his bill. But the mayor is just as afraid of Khlestakov, since he believes Khlestakov is the government inspector. Therefore, to win Khlestakov's favor, the mayor slips him extra money and offers Khlestakov a room in his own house. Pleased with this unexpected fortune, Khlestakov relaxes and accepts the mayor's hospitality.

Later, Khlestakov and the town officials return to the mayor's house from a tour of the town's institutions and a delicious lunch at the charity hospital. Khlestakov drunkenly boasts about his luxurious life and high status with increasing exaggeration, until he thoroughly terrifies the officials.

The next day, each town official presents himself formally to Khlestakov. Khlestakov takes advantage of their eagerness to

please him and asks for loans from all of them. Only after these interviews does Khlestakov realize that the officials have mistaken him for some other important figure. Khlestakov laughs at them and writes a letter to his friend in St. Petersburg recounting the officials' foolishness. Then, according to Osip's advice, Khlestakov makes plans to leave. As he does so, shopkeepers and other townspeople gather to present petitions to Khlestakov. He listens to their complaints about the mayor's many misdeeds and promises vaguely to help them, but soon he grows tired of listening to them and sends the rest away.

Khlestakov meets Marya Antonovna, the mayor's daughter, while she's alone and flirts with her. When her mother Anna Andreyevna walks in, Khlestakov suddenly proclaims his love to Anna instead. Then he switches back to declaring undying love for Marya. The mayor and his wife give their blessings for the couple's union, and Khlestakov becomes betrothed to Marya. At that moment, Osip informs Khlestakov that his carriage is ready, and Khlestakov departs with a promise to return tomorrow.

The mayor and his wife smugly celebrate their daughter's engagement to Khlestakov. They fantasize about living in St. Petersburg and rising in status, and they enjoy everyone's congratulations on their extraordinary good fortune. However, their happiness is interrupted by the postmaster's entrance. In front of all the mayor's guests, the postmaster reveals the devastating contents of Khlestakov's letter. The officials discover that Khlestakov was never the government inspector at all and that they've duped themselves. The mayor curses his own stupidity and delivers a tirade about being turned into the world's laughingstock.

Suddenly, a gendarme enters and announces that the real government inspector has arrived and demands the officials' presence at the inn. In shock, everyone freezes into a silent tableau.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Khlestakov – Ivan Aleksandrovich Khlestakov is a low-ranking government official who lives in St. Petersburg. Around 23 years old, he's slim and fashionably dressed. He's sincere but not very intelligent, and he often speaks and acts without thinking. Khlestakov is also irresponsible and self-indulgent, with a weakness for good **food**, cigars, and women. His selfish pleasure-seeking leads him and his servant Osip to be stranded without travel funds in the provincial Russian town in which the play takes place. Seeing Khlestakov at the inn, town residents Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky assume he is a government inspector. When the town officials begin to bribe him so that he won't report their corruption to higher authorities, Khlestakov

happily accepts their generosity. Unknowingly, Khlestakov confirms the officials' false belief that he's the inspector by exaggerating his rank and status, which he does simply because he wants their admiration. He flirts with both Anna Andreyevna, the mayor's wife, and Marya Antonovna, the mayor's daughter, and he even becomes engaged to Marya. Before he leaves, Khlestakov finally realizes that the town officials have mistaken him for someone more important than he is, and he laughs at their foolishness.

The Mayor – Anton Antonovich Skvoznik-Dmukhanovsky is the town's mayor. The mayor regularly takes bribes and steals from shopkeepers, whom he accuses of being swindlers. He's also aware of the other local officials' poor conduct, but he has no intention of addressing any problems with the town's governance, because he benefits from the pervasive corruption. When he receives news that a government inspector is coming to investigate his district, the mayor is terrified that he'll be caught and punished for his many sins. Once the mayor believes Khlestakov is the inspector, he rushes to win Khlestakov's favor through bribery and lies. He also frantically urges Khlestakov not to listen to the shopkeepers' complaints about him. When his wife Anna Andreyevna tells him that Khlestakov wants to marry his daughter Marya Antonovna, the mayor doesn't believe it. Soon, however, the mayor fantasizes about moving to St. Petersburg, becoming a general, and living in high society. He's quick to gloat over the shopkeepers and solicit congratulations from everyone as soon as he thinks his good fortune is secured. At the end of the play, his happiness turns into fury when the postmaster reveals that Khlestakov is, in fact, not the government inspector.

The Judge – Ammos Fyodorovich Lyapkin-Tyapkin is the judge. He's pompous and solemn, and he considers himself an intellectual. The judge has received an award for his long service in office, but he is corrupt, incompetent, and neglectful of his duties, just like the other town officials. He openly admits to taking bribes, and he can't make sense of court records. He cares more about his hobbies—hunting and raising hunting dogs—than his job. Additionally, he uses the courthouse as a place to kennel his dogs and store his personal belongings. According to the Warden of Charities, the judge is also carrying on a long-term affair with Dobchinsky's wife. Despite his many misdeeds, the judge is the least concerned about the government inspector's arrival, because he's confident the inspector won't investigate the courts. Still, the judge becomes anxious to impress Khlestakov, and nervously bribes Khlestakov to ensure that the courts won't be inspected.

Warden of Charities – Artemy Filippovich Zemlyanika is the Warden of Charities. He's rotund and clumsy, yet crafty, unscrupulous, and servile. The Warden of Charities runs the charity hospital, but he severely neglects his duties. He chooses not to treat patients with medicine and manages the hospital very poorly. He feels little guilt about his misconduct; he only

dreads getting caught by the government inspector. To win over Khlestakov, who he believes is the inspector, the Warden of Charities serves Khlestakov a **delicious lunch** at the charity hospital, while he doesn't even provide hospital patients with proper meals. This demonstrates the Warden of Charities' eagerness to protect himself from being reported to the authorities, as well as his indifference to his responsibilities. To further win Khlestakov's favor, the Warden of Charities proposes that each town official should meet with Khlestakov individually. When it's his turn to present himself to Khlestakov, the Warden of Charities double-crosses his fellow officials by exposing their many crimes. He also ridicules the mayor behind his back on more than one occasion. At the end of the play, the Warden of Charities is shocked that Khlestakov wasn't the government inspector and blames the devil's influence for the officials' mistake.

Inspector of Schools – Luka Lukich Khlopov is the Inspector of Schools. Like the other town officials, the Inspector of Schools doesn't perform his duty well. In fact, the Inspector of Schools has trouble controlling the teachers, who spread subversive ideas and misbehave in classrooms. The Inspector of Schools is nervous about the government inspector's arrival, and he's so afraid to talk to people of higher rank than him that during his one-on-one meeting with Khlestakov, he drops a cigar out of fright and becomes too shy to answer Khlestakov's questions. He timidly gives Khlestakov a loan and hopes that Khlestakov won't investigate the schools. When the mayor announces his daughter's engagement to Khlestakov and boasts about his good fortune, the Inspector of Schools congratulates the mayor out loud; however, to himself, he spitefully calls the mayor a pig. At the end of the play, the Inspector of Schools is innocently bewildered by the announcement that the real government inspector has arrived after all.

Postmaster – Ivan Kuzmich Shpekin is the postmaster. He is so simple-minded that he's naïve. Out of curiosity, he opens and reads everyone's mail. Sometimes, he even keeps letters for himself that are particularly enjoyable to read. At the mayor's request, he cheerfully agrees to intercept any letters that might inform higher authorities about the mayor's corruption. Like the other town officials, the postmaster is easily convinced that Khlestakov must be the government inspector. When asked, the postmaster happily gives Khlestakov a loan, leading Khlestakov to praise the postmaster's decency and willingness to please. After Khlestakov leaves town, the postmaster reads Khlestakov's letter for fear that Khlestakov has reported him to the authorities. By doing so, the postmaster becomes the first person to discover that Khlestakov is, in fact, not the government inspector, and he reports this news to the other town officials.

Bobchinsky – Pyotr Ivanovich Bobchinsky is a local landowner in the town. He's short and portly in stature, speaks rapidly, and gestures wildly. Bobchinsky is comically similar to his fellow

landowner Dobchinsky, although Bobchinsky is more energetic. Highly curious but unintelligent, he and Dobchinsky are the first people to see Khlestakov in town and assume he's the government inspector. As a result, Bobchinsky is partially responsible for Khlestakov's mistaken identity.

Dobchinsky – Pyotr Ivanovich Dobchinsky is a local landowner in the town. He's nearly identical to Bobchinsky in name, appearance, and mannerisms, although Dobchinsky is taller and more serious. He and Bobchinsky constantly interrupt and bicker with each other while speaking. Along with Bobchinsky, he's responsible for spreading the false assumption that Khlestakov is the government inspector.

Anna Andreyevna – Anna Andreyevna is the mayor's wife and mother of Marya Antonovna. Anna is vain and self-centered. She must always look her best, demands to be in the know, talks long-windedly, and constantly fusses and complains. She bickers incessantly with her daughter and often rebukes Marya unkindly. Anna is also easily caught up in the excitement about the government inspector's arrival. Instead of fearing the reason for the inspector's visit, she's immediately curious about the inspector's looks and rank. Her focus on superficial things reflects her own petty shallowness. After Anna is introduced to Khlestakov, she enjoys Khlestakov's flattery and is taken in by his ridiculous boasting. Even while her daughter is being congratulated for her recent engagement to Khlestakov, Anna makes herself the center of attention, as if she's the bride-to-be instead of Marya. Furthermore, once she believes Marya will soon be married to a very important man, Anna is quick to fantasize about leaving behind her provincial home, disregarding the coarse and uncultivated people with whom she currently lives, and mixing with polite society in St. Petersburg. Like the mayor, she sets her sights over-ambitiously on attaining social prestige and living a luxurious life.

Marya Antonovna – Marya Antonovna is the 18-year-old daughter of the mayor and Anna Andreyevna. Marya is quiet and meek, constantly being chastised by her mother for being vain, clumsy, and immature. However, she is more polite, observant, and clear-headed than her mother. Nevertheless, after seeing Khlestakov—the supposed government inspector—for the first time, Marya admires his looks and is easily dazzled by his city manners. Shortly after Khlestakov professes his undying love for her, she is engaged to him with her parents' blessing.

Osip – Osip is Khlestakov's servant. An older man, Osip is serious, reserved, and practical. Although he keeps his criticisms to himself, he disapproves of Khlestakov's self-indulgent nature, irresponsibility with money, tendency to show off, and aversion to honest work. Osip is more level-headed and realistic than Khlestakov. He wisely persuades Khlestakov to leave town before anybody discovers he's not the government inspector after all. However, Osip is still

opportunistic. Taking advantage of favorable circumstances, he allows the town officials to believe his master is of higher status than he actually is. Osip also eagerly accepts **food** and money whenever possible, even when they're being offered as bribes. Additionally, like Khlestakov, Osip particularly enjoys receiving respect and recognition above his station. One of his favorite things about St. Petersburg is that people there call him "sir." This social validation allows him to pretend as if he's a gentleman when, in reality, he's only a servant.

Korobkin – Stepan Ivanovich Korobkin is a retired official and respected citizen of the town. After the mayor announces his daughter Marya Antonovna's supposed engagement to Khlestakov, Korobkin and his wife congratulate the mayor's family on their recent good fortune. Although Korobkin seems outwardly friendly and respectful to the mayor, the end of the play reveals that Korobkin doesn't actually like the mayor. In the Mute Scene, Korobkin winks at the audience and directs contempt toward the mayor, inviting the audience to share his disdain for the mayor and his foolishness.

Rastakovsky – Ivan Lazarevich Rastakovsky is a retired official and respected citizen of the town. In a friendly manner, Rastakovsky congratulates the mayor and Anna Andreyevna on their daughter Marya Antonovna's engagement to Khlestakov. He wishes for Marya and Khlestakov to be blessed with long lives and many offspring. His name means "to be a yes-man."

Abdulin – Abdulin is a shopkeeper who sells wine. According to the mayor, Abdulin is scheming and duplicitous. The mayor curses Abdulin for knowing how scratched up his **sword** is but still not sending him a new one. Because he believes Khlestakov is a very high-ranking government official, Abdulin addresses a petition to Khlestakov complaining about the mayor's misconduct.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Lyulyukov – Fyodor Andreyevich Lyulyukov is a retired official and respected citizen of the town. Lyulyukov congratulates Anna Andreyevna and Marya Antonovna on Marya's supposed betrothal to Khlestakov with great attention-seeking bravado.

Chief of Police – Stepan Ilich Ukhovoyortov is the Chief of Police. He follows the mayor's orders obediently, but under his command the police constables are disorderly and ill-behaved. His name means "ear-twister," which implies that he treats people roughly and violently.

Svistunov – Svistunov is a constable. The mayor berates him for stealing from townspeople and taking bribes above his rank.

Mishka – Mishka is the mayor's servant.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-

coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



CORRUPTION AND BUREAUCRACY

The Government Inspector, a play set in a provincial Russian town in the 1830s, satirizes the rampant political corruption of local government officials and petty bureaucrats. The play does so by presenting all the town officials as inept and self-serving. The mayor takes bribes and steals from townspeople without scruple. The judge also takes bribes; the Warden of Charities doesn't feed charity hospital patients properly or treat them with medicine; and the police are often drunk and violent. The local officials know their crookedness is wrong, but they feel no guilt about their misconduct because they benefit from how unjustly they run the town. The mayor himself excuses his misdeeds with the lighthearted claim that every man has "some little indiscretion on his conscience." Overall, the town officials' foolish antics throughout the play as they try to hide their blatant corruption showcase the total incompetence of the town's governance. Additionally, Khlestakov, a visitor to the town who is presumed to be the government inspector, represents the bureaucracy's inefficacy. Irresponsible and light-minded, he has no real governmental power, and he doesn't take his work seriously. Nevertheless, even his minor clerical position in St. Petersburg inflates his ego, and Khlestakov is happy to let the ignorant town officials treat him like a magnificent lord. Through Khlestakov, the play mocks bureaucrats whose only importance lies superficially in their titles and who are otherwise self-indulgent simpletons. By portraying the comical absurdity of the officials' maladministration, stupidity, and self-importance, the play ridicules and criticizes the bureaucratic system of 19th-century Russia.



GREED, SELFISHNESS, AND PLEASURE

In *The Government Inspector*, Khlestakov and the town officials prioritize their own pleasure over everything else. On one hand, Khlestakov's pleasure-seeking causes him to neglect his duties, avoid responsibility, and be a wholly ineffectual civil servant. Instead of working, Khlestakov plays card games and gambles his money away. He can't resist good **food**, cigars, and women. He even states that the main purpose of life is to "pluck the blossoms of pleasure." In other words, Khlestakov is preoccupied with his own ease and pleasure, which leads him to do his job as a government official poorly. On the other hand, the town officials are especially guilty of greedily fulfilling their selfish desires at the expense of other people—namely, the townspeople they are supposed to govern properly. For instance, the postmaster reads people's private letters, because

he's curious and enjoys the stories in them. The judge takes bribes so he can fund his hobby of raising hunting dogs. And the mayor takes anything that catches his eye—valuable or not—from shops without compensating the shopkeepers. The local officials' selfish greediness is the source of the town's corruption and clearly marks them as morally reprehensible authority figures. Moreover, the play encourages the audience to laugh at the officials' desperate attempts to preserve their selfish ways without getting caught by the government inspector. Their efforts comically backfire on them, and by the end of the play they're still beholden to the real government inspector, which suggests that the officials cannot—and should not—get away with their crimes of greed. Through the examples of Khlestakov and the town officials, *The Government Inspector* satirizes greed, selfishness, and pleasure-seeking, suggesting that while such traits are universal among humans, they are perhaps best exemplified by government officials.



EXTERNAL VALIDATION

Many of the characters in *The Government Inspector* are motivated by the desire for external validation. When Khlestakov says, "After all, what does one really need? Only to be respected and genuinely liked," he reveals his longing for outside approval. He frequently shows off and presents himself as more impressive than he actually is to attract other people's adoration. Yet, in reality, Khlestakov is nobody important, nor does he do any honest work to earn the respect and admiration he desires. Similarly, the mayor puts more effort into *seeming* a good mayor when he thinks the government inspector has arrived than he does into *being* a good mayor. He hurries to make superficial changes to the town to conceal corruption instead of addressing the townspeople's complaints. Also, as soon as the mayor believes his daughter Marya Antonovna will marry an important man, he solicits everyone's congratulations to enhance his own reputation and self-importance. Like Khlestakov, the mayor wants attention, respect, and admiration from the people around him, although he does nothing to earn these things. Furthermore, at the end of the play, the mayor and other town officials are more upset that Khlestakov has turned them into laughingstocks than they are remorseful about their numerous wrongdoings. More than anything else, the officials care about their images. By showing how morally corrupt and foolish these characters are, the play exposes a comically large gap between the admiration they desire and the ridicule they deserve. In doing so, the play ultimately ridicules people who are so morally corrupt that they believe external validation for appearing good is more important than actually doing good.



SELF-DECEPTION

Khlestakov's mistaken identity as the feared government inspector from St. Petersburg is crucial to the plot and comedy of *The Government Inspector*. Importantly, Khlestakov never intentionally pretends to be the inspector to deceive the town officials. He isn't aware that they think he's a government inspector at all; he simply takes advantage of their eagerness to please him, because he desires other people's admiration. In fact, the only real deception in the play is the town officials' self-deception. As soon as the officials conclude—without proof—that Khlestakov must be the inspector, they give more and more weight to this idea until they accept it as unquestionable fact. They begin to view Khlestakov as intimidating, cultured, dignified, and immensely powerful, which only further persuades them that he is the inspector. The local officials' self-deception prevents them from seeing the reality that Khlestakov is only a minor clerk and lacks the impressive qualities they attach to him. In the end, the mayor finally realizes they have all duped themselves and cries, "Was there anything like a government inspector about that whippersnapper? Absolutely damn all." With these words, the mayor admits that Khlestakov never really seemed like an inspector; it was only the mayor's and the other officials' false belief that transformed Khlestakov into the inspector in their minds. Beyond the humor of Khlestakov's mistaken identity and the town officials' foolishness, the play demonstrates how powerful self-deception can be. *The Government Inspector* suggests that when people see only what is easy or desirable to believe, they ignore reality to their own detriment.

townspeople. Additionally, the mayor curses Abdulin, a shopkeeper, for not sending him a new sword. The mayor doesn't take proper care of his sword or his mayoral duties, but instead of recognizing his own guilt, he simply shifts the blame onto townspeople. Thus, the sword reflects the mayor's personal moral corruption and misadministration of the town. Furthermore, the mayor's sword symbolizes not only the mayor's individual failings but also the widespread political corruption in the town more broadly. When the mayor first visits Khlestakov—the purported government inspector—he wears his sword to reinforce his sense of authority and to appear more impressive. But the mayor can't repair his damaged sword any more than he can superficially fix the problems with the town's greedy officials and ill-managed institutions. The mayor's inability to hide the deteriorated state of his sword demonstrates his inability to cover up the town's corrupt governance.



FOOD

In *The Government Inspector*, food is a recurring symbol of characters' self-centered pursuits of pleasure. For Khlestakov, good food is all-important. Both he and Osip mention his love of good food numerous times. In fact, Khlestakov is initially characterized by his desire for food; during his first appearance on stage, he complains that he's starving and begs for lunch. Beyond the simple need to eat, Khlestakov's fixation on good food represents his pleasure-seeking tendencies overall. Just as he yearns to have ample delicious food without paying for it, Khlestakov seeks to live a life of comfort and ease while neglecting his duties. In other words, food stands symbolically for all of the pleasures Khlestakov self-indulgently chases instead of performing his responsibilities as a government official. Even Khlestakov's attraction to women is likened to his appreciation of good food; when he admires Anna Andreyevna, he calls her a "tasty dish." In this way, food signifies Khlestakov's desire for pleasure, which motivates all his actions.

For the town officials, food especially symbolizes the greediness of their pursuits of pleasure. The mayor takes bribes in the form of food items—such as sugar—from shopkeepers, enhancing his own pleasure at townspeople's expense. And the mayor is not the only town official who eats well while depriving other people of food. Most glaringly, the Warden of Charities serves Khlestakov "fine cuisine" at the charity hospital, even though his hospital patients are being fed only cabbage. This "splendid lunch" is selfish not only because the Warden of Charities gets to enjoy good food, but also because he uses the meal as a bribe to persuade Khlestakov against reporting him to the authorities. As this example demonstrates, the town officials' enjoyment of good food signifies their harmful, self-serving greed as they strive to fulfill their own desires above all else.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



THE MAYOR'S SWORD

The mayor's sword symbolizes the mayor's personal corruption, as well as the political corruption that pervades the whole town under the mayor's governance. On its own, a sword is a symbol of power and authority. The town officials—including the judge, postmaster, Inspector of Schools, and Warden of Charities—all wear swords as part of their formal, full-dress uniforms. Their swords therefore function as visual signs of their ranks and government positions. In the same way, the mayor's sword also represents the mayor's power. However, in the mayor's case, the sword's "poor condition" signifies how corrupt the mayor is. He exclaims, "Hell! My sword's scratched all over." Just as the sword is blemished, so the mayor's authority is tarnished by his misconduct, such as taking bribes and stealing from



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Penguin edition of *The Diary of a Madman, The Government Inspector and Selected Stories* published in 2006.

Act 1 Quotes

☞ I had a kind of premonition about this. All last night I dreamt about a couple of extraordinary rats—they were black and absolutely enormous. They came in, took a few sniffs and off they went.

Related Characters: The Mayor (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 219

Explanation and Analysis

At the beginning of the play, the mayor informs the other town officials that a government inspector is coming to investigate them. This news reminds the mayor of a dream he had the previous night, which he believes was actually a premonition about the inspector. While the mayor's mention of his dream seems comically odd and out of place, it offers useful insight into what the mayor thinks of the inspector. The mayor identifies the inspector with the rats from his dream, which were "extraordinary" and "absolutely enormous." This suggests that the mayor likewise views the inspector as an "extraordinary" or very important person, because he's likely a high-ranking man from St. Petersburg, the imperial capital.

However, the mayor also sees the inspector as a mere rat who will come, sniff around town, and then leave. This shows that the mayor has little respect for the inspector and derogatorily considers him a traitorous informer. On one hand, the mayor's disdain for the inspector is consistent with his desire not to be investigated or caught committing crimes. On the other hand, it's ironic for the mayor to think of the inspector as a rat, because the corrupt and dishonest mayor is himself a "rat," or despicable person. This irony hints at the very real justification for the government inspector's visit: the political corruption pervading the town due to the mayor's poor administration.

☞ I don't need to tell you that there isn't a man alive who hasn't some little indiscretion on his conscience.

Related Characters: The Mayor (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 222

Explanation and Analysis

Having been warned about a government inspector's imminent arrival, the mayor defends his many misdeeds by claiming that every man has "some little indiscretion on his conscience." The mayor implies that if everyone is guilty in some way, then it should be understandable and acceptable for him to have committed small sins too. Such reasoning illustrates how morally corrupt the mayor is. First, he downplays his crimes—which include stealing from townspeople and taking bribes—by calling them "little indiscretion[s]." This understatement suggests that the mayor has made minor mistakes in the past, when in reality the mayor continually chooses to abuse his power to satisfy his selfish greed. Second, the mayor insinuates that since nobody is perfect, his own wrongdoings are excusable. But other people's faults don't absolve the mayor of the harm he inflicts on the town's inhabitants by taking advantage of them while neglecting his mayoral duties. Third, these words suggest that the mayor feels little remorse for his misconduct—in reality, he's only afraid of being caught in the wrong. The mayor's moral failings are apparent from early on in the play, and the defensiveness he demonstrates here make them all the more obvious.

☞ Hell! My sword's scratched all over. That damned shopkeeper Abdulin knows very well the mayor's sword's in poor condition and still he doesn't send me a new one.

Related Characters: The Mayor (speaker), Abdulin

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 230

Explanation and Analysis

After the mayor decides to speak to the supposed government inspector, he asks for his sword to be brought to him. The mayor's sword is part of his formal uniform. And it visually represents his authority, which is why he wants to wear it when he meets the inspector. However, the mayor's sword doesn't look impressive. It's "scratched all over" and

“in poor condition,” as the mayor complains. In its damaged state, the sword signifies that the mayor’s authority is tainted by corruption. Just like the mayor has taken poor care of his sword, he has neglected his duties and abused his power to terrorize townspeople for his own benefit. And just as the mayor can’t hide or fix the scratches on his sword, he can’t realistically conceal or rectify the town’s poor governance—to which he contributes. In these ways, the mayor’s sword symbolizes both his personal corruption and the broader political corruption that he enables.

Importantly, the mayor doesn’t accept responsibility for the deterioration of his sword or his dereliction of duty. Instead, he curses Abdulin, a shopkeeper, for not replacing the mayor’s sword. The mayor’s eagerness to insult a townspeople demonstrates how little respect the mayor has for the citizens he governs. Moreover, the mayor seems to think that the only problem in town is the townspeople’s lack of loyalty, whereas his own misconduct is the much bigger problem. The mayor doesn’t see his flaws and instead blames other people for issues that stem from his corruption.

☞ You watch it! You can’t pull the wool over my eyes. What did you do to that draper Chernayev, eh? He gave you two yards of cloth for a new uniform and you swiped the whole roll! You watch out! You’re taking bribes above your rank!

Related Characters: The Mayor (speaker), Khlestakov, The Judge, Svistunov

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 231

Explanation and Analysis

While the mayor prepares to meet Khlestakov, the supposed government inspector, he orders the constable Svistunov to help clean up the town. As he does so, he also admonishes Svistunov for stealing a “whole roll” of cloth from a townspeople. The mayor’s reproach reveals that the town’s police are also corrupt. Like the town officials—such as the mayor and the judge—the constables also abuse their authority by stealing and taking bribes. However, the mayor isn’t angry simply because Svistunov accepted a bribe. Rather, the mayor is upset that Svistunov is taking bribes “above [his] rank.”

First, these words suggest that selfish crimes of greed are so common in this town that taking bribes is accepted as a

norm among authority figures under the corrupt mayor’s governance. Second, the mayor means that although it’s fine for Svistunov to take bribes, he should only do so according to his rank. In other words, as a mere constable, Svistunov should accept only small bribes and leave larger takings for higher-ranking officials, such as the mayor himself. This rule enforced by the mayor ensures that townspeople are preyed upon by everyone who has any power over them, but it also ensures that the mayor—the highest-ranking official in town—benefits the most from being greedy/ Thus, by rebuking Svistunov, the mayor reveals more of the corruption and greed that plague the town.

☞ Now you listen, this is what you must do. Constable Pugovitsyn is very tall, so station him on the bridge to create a good impression. And tell them to pull down that old fence by the shoemaker’s and stick up some poles to make it look like a building site. The more we pull down the busier the mayor will appear.

Related Characters: The Mayor (speaker), Chief of Police

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 231

Explanation and Analysis

Once the mayor believes the government inspector has already arrived, he rushes to make the town more presentable for the inspector. So, he instructs the Chief of Police to set up constables around town to make “a good impression.” The mayor’s own words show that he’s only interested in improving the town’s appearance superficially. It doesn’t matter to the mayor that the constables are known for incompetency and abuses of authority. Instead, the mayor simply cares that a tall constable standing on a bridge will look good. Similarly, the mayor orders the Chief of Police to create the illusion of a building site so he can pretend he’s busy establishing new infrastructure in town. However, this is a clear lie, and the slapdash way in which the mayor hurries to create a false impression of his diligence only exposes how negligent of his responsibilities he ordinarily is.

The corrupt mayor explicitly wants to “appear” as a commendable town official, but he’s unwilling to do any work that would actually make him one. Moreover, the mayor’s desperate attempts to cast himself in a good light showcase his ridiculousness. Surely, a capable government inspector wouldn’t be persuaded by a single tall constable or “some poles” to believe that the mayor is performing his

duties well. Such flimsy measures can't conceal pervasive political corruption. By portraying the mayor as such a comic fool, the play mocks corrupt local government officials.

Act 2 Quotes

☞ But no: he has to show off in every town. "I say, Osip," he tells me, "fish around and find me the best room and order a first-rate dinner—no inferior cooking for me, nothing but the best will do." It wouldn't be so bad if he really was a somebody, but he's just a lousy little clerk.

Related Characters: Osip (speaker), Khlestakov

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 234

Explanation and Analysis

Stranded at the inn in town, Osip complains about Khlestakov, his master. According to Osip, Khlestakov demands the highest luxuries even though he can hardly afford them. While traveling, he claims he needs to stay in "the best room" and always eat "a first-rate dinner," because only "the best will do" for him. Osip's gripes demonstrate that Khlestakov is self-indulgent and pleasure-seeking. He greedily chases after comfort and satisfaction without thinking responsibly. Significantly, Khlestakov seems to desire good food in particular. Osip emphasizes that Khlestakov doesn't want any "inferior cooking," but only the best meals. For Khlestakov, food has special importance and symbolizes pleasure in general, which he single-mindedly pursues.

Osip is especially irritated that Khlestakov insists on enjoying luxuries as a means to "show off" everywhere he goes, not just to satisfy his own desires. This reflects Khlestakov's longing for outside approval. He wants other people to be impressed by him and treat him with great respect and admiration. But Osip thinks Khlestakov's wish for such external validation is ridiculous. Khlestakov isn't "a somebody"—an important person who might actually deserve attention and esteem. Rather, Khlestakov is a nobody, "just a lousy little clerk." From Osip's perspective, Khlestakov is foolish for seeking recognition above his station. Indeed, the sharp contrast between who Khlestakov is and the grand individual he wants to be treated as suggests that Khlestakov is selfish and pretentious.

☞ And I'm like you—I've no time for two-faced people. I find your frankness and cordiality most gratifying. I do confess that I ask for nothing more out of life than devotion and respect, respect and devotion.

Related Characters: Khlestakov (speaker), The Mayor

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 245-246

Explanation and Analysis

After the mayor invites Khlestakov to stay in his home, Khlestakov accepts gratefully and compliments the mayor's sincerity. The irony of Khlestakov's words is striking. Khlestakov claims he has "no time for two-faced people" without knowing how dishonest the mayor actually is. The mayor is lying to Khlestakov about not only his magnanimous spirit but also the reason for his generosity. The mayor's hospitality isn't motivated by "frankness" or "cordiality," as Khlestakov believes, but instead by an ulterior motive. Through bribery, the mayor intends to win Khlestakov's favor so that Khlestakov—as the supposed government inspector—won't report the mayor's corruption to the authorities. In other words, the mayor's kindness to Khlestakov is really self-preservation and evidence of the mayor's corruption. Khlestakov, however, is unaware of the mayor's true motives or the circumstances that have led to his mistaking Khlestakov for a government inspector. As a result, Khlestakov humorously praises the mayor for virtues he doesn't possess.

Additionally, Khlestakov admits that he wants "nothing more out of life than devotion and respect, respect and devotion." Here, Khlestakov articulates that his greatest desire in life is external validation. He wants other people to respect, love, and admire him. But just like the mayor is undeserving of Khlestakov's praise, so too is Khlestakov undeserving of the great "devotion" and "respect" he craves. The mayor is only treating Khlestakov well because he believes Khlestakov is the inspector, and Khlestakov hasn't done anything to merit such high regard and dedication from other people. Nevertheless, Khlestakov foolishly seeks unearned respect and admiration from the mayor.

Act 3 Quotes

☞ No, not a general, but he's as good as one. So cultured, so dignified.

Related Characters: Dobchinsky (speaker), Khlestakov,

The Mayor, Anna Andreyevna, Marya Antonovna

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 250

Explanation and Analysis

After he returns to the mayor's house from the inn, Dobchinsky answers Anna Andreyevna's insistent questions about the supposed government inspector. By his description, Dobchinsky seems quite awed by Khlestakov. Dobchinsky says that Khlestakov isn't as high-ranking as a general but is still "as good as one." This means that Dobchinsky perceives Khlestakov as having the same gravitas as a very powerful, high-status member of the civil service. Additionally, Khlestakov appears "[so] cultured, so dignified" to Dobchinsky. In Dobchinsky's mind, then, Khlestakov is a greatly impressive and intimidating man, and Dobchinsky spreads this impression of Khlestakov to Anna Andreyevna and Marya Antonovna.

Dobchinsky's conception of Khlestakov is humorous because the play's audience knows it's inaccurate. A feather-brained minor clerk, Khlestakov is neither extremely "cultured" nor particularly "dignified." The huge gap between Dobchinsky's version of Khlestakov and the real Khlestakov makes Dobchinsky seem like a gullible fool and poor judge of character. He's easily impressed because he himself is not very sophisticated.

More importantly, Dobchinsky's description of Khlestakov reveals that he's seeing what he wants to believe. Dobchinsky has already identified Khlestakov as the government inspector, and he assumes that inspectors should be powerful and intimidating men. So, Dobchinsky perceives Khlestakov according to his preconceived notions, regardless of reality. Unbeknownst to Khlestakov, Dobchinsky has deceived himself about Khlestakov's identity and is now spreading his misconception to the mayor's wife and daughter. Khlestakov's mistaken identity gives rise to extensive dramatic irony, in which the play's audience knows who Khlestakov really is and can laugh at ignorant characters, such as Dobchinsky, who are so confidently wrong.

☞ Now, Mashenka, we have to decide what to wear. He's a Petersburg man-about-town, so I hope he won't laugh at us.

Related Characters: Anna Andreyevna (speaker),

Khlestakov, The Mayor, Marya Antonovna

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 252

Explanation and Analysis

After she learns that Khlestakov will be staying in the mayor's house, Anna Andreyevna immediately wonders how she can impress the man she believes is the government inspector. Specifically, Anna is concerned about "what to wear." Her focus on clothes and appearances underscores her vanity, shallowness, and self-centeredness. She also wants her daughter, Marya Antonovna, to look her best so Khlestakov "won't laugh at" them. This fear of derision suggests that Anna desires Khlestakov's acceptance, or approval. She wants to be admired and respected by other people. Like many other characters in the play, Anna displays a need for external validation through her insistence on being the center of attention and the recipient of praise.

Moreover, Anna's words reveal her view of Khlestakov. She calls him "a Petersburg man-about-town," which indicates that she expects him to be fashionable and sophisticated. Before she has even met Khlestakov, she has a high opinion of him and wants to present herself flatteringly to him. Anna's desire to impress Khlestakov shows how quickly she's swept up in the excitement of his presence, even though he's not the real inspector.

☞ I'm mad about good food. But what else is life for except to pluck the blossoms of pleasure...

Related Characters: Khlestakov (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 254

Explanation and Analysis

After eating lunch at the charity hospital with some of the town officials, Khlestakov muses about how delicious the food was. He also expresses how significant food is to him in general, saying, "I'm mad about good food." Furthermore, he reveals that in his mind food and pleasure are inextricably linked. When he says, "what else is life for except to pluck the blossoms of pleasure," Khlestakov implies that the entire

purpose of living is to experience pleasure—and, more specifically, to eat good food. This flowery statement indicates that Khlestakov is motivated wholly by his desire for pleasure, comfort, and ease. Food is central to his pursuits of pleasure, because food symbolically represents the pleasurable self-indulgence Khlestakov craves.

Crucially, Khlestakov's preoccupation with food and pleasure makes him short-sighted and self-centered. He's so easily distracted by tasty fish that he doesn't notice how the town officials are trying to conceal their corruption, embellish their reputations with lies, and bribe Khlestakov. Additionally, Khlestakov is oblivious to the fact that he's only being treated with so much generosity because he's been mistaken for a government inspector.

☞ Once I was even taken for the Commander-in-Chief himself. The soldiers leapt out of the guardroom and presented arms. Afterwards an officer—a great friend of mine—told me: “Well, old man, we really did think you were the Commander-in-Chief!”

Related Characters: Khlestakov (speaker), The Mayor

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 257

Explanation and Analysis

In front of the town officials and the mayor's family, Khlestakov exaggerates about his life in St. Petersburg, claiming to be a far more important government official than he actually is. He pretends he was once mistaken “for the Commander-in-Chief himself,” someone much higher-ranking than him. Supposedly, Khlestakov made such a powerful impression that “soldiers leapt out of the guardroom” and “presented arms” to show their respect to him. Khlestakov implies that he's so impressive that other people can't help but honor him, even when he's not trying to attract attention. This made-up story shows how much Khlestakov desires other people's admiration and respect. Not only does he invent a scenario in which he receives the external validation he craves, but also—by telling this tale—he encourages the town officials to offer him similar reverence. Because this story is obviously untrue, Khlestakov's farfetched aspirations to be treated with such great respect and devotion appear foolish, and the town officials seem gullible for taking Khlestakov seriously.

Meanwhile, the play's audience can appreciate the double

layer of dramatic irony that Khlestakov's words create. On one hand, Khlestakov doesn't know he's currently being mistaken for a government inspector, which is why the town officials are entertaining him so generously in the first place. His hyperbolic story about misidentification unknowingly mirrors the situation he's in now. On the other hand, the town officials don't understand that Khlestakov isn't intentionally trying to frighten or deceive them in this moment. Rather, he's simply seeking favorable attention from them. Khlestakov has no ulterior motive because he isn't the government inspector, as the officials incorrectly believe.

☞ Well, the more I think about it...hell!...my head's going round! I feel as if I were perched on top of a steeple or as if I had a noose round my neck.

Related Characters: The Mayor (speaker), Khlestakov

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 262

Explanation and Analysis

After Khlestakov brags about his luxurious, high-status life in St. Petersburg, he exits to rest, leaving the frightened mayor to decide which of Khlestakov's statements were true and which were fanciful, drunken exaggerations. The mayor has difficulty identifying the truth, and his head starts to spin, as he complains here: “Well, the more I think about it...hell!...my head's going round!” The mayor's conviction that Khlestakov must be the government inspector prevents him from recognizing that Khlestakov is, in fact, a low-ranking clerk whose self-aggrandizing boasts were all false. The mayor's self-deception has powerfully disoriented him.

The mayor emphasizes how dizzying and bewildering self-deception is when he says he feels as though he “were perched on top of a steeple.” By jumping to conclusions about Khlestakov's identity and ignoring reality, the mayor has unbalanced himself, like someone trying to stand on a tall, narrow spire. Furthermore, the mayor ominously adds that he feels like he has “a noose round [his] neck.” These words suggest that the mayor perceives himself to be in a fatally precarious situation. He fears that, at any moment, he might lose his balance and fall from the imagined steeple, or that the figurative noose around his neck will tighten. These images of impending danger refer to the mayor's worry of being caught by the government inspector. The

mayor feels that getting caught would be his ultimate downfall, as dreadful and final as falling off a steeple or death by hanging. While the mayor thinks Khlestakov is the source of the approaching danger he's envisioning, the play's audience already knows that the mayor is mistaken about Khlestakov's identity. Thus, the mayor's foreboding words hint that his self-deception is the greater threat and likelier cause of his own downfall.

☛ The whole world's gone topsy-turvy.

Related Characters: The Mayor (speaker), Khlestakov

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 262

Explanation and Analysis

The mayor exclaims that the “whole world's gone topsy-turvy” after he hears Khlestakov boast about how powerful and high-ranking he is. The mayor feels bewildered because he believes Khlestakov is as important as he exaggeratedly claims, even though Khlestakov looks ordinary and unimpressive on the outside. From the mayor's perspective, it doesn't make sense for Khlestakov to be so different from how he appears. Therefore, the perplexed mayor concludes that everything in the world has become the opposite of what it should be.

The mayor's confusion is humorous because the play's audience understands that the mayor is mistaken. In fact, Khlestakov is only a minor clerk and a sincere, lightminded fool, just as he appears to be. Reality isn't as distorted as the mayor thinks, nor is Khlestakov as crafty as the mayor suspects. Instead, the mayor has distorted reality for himself by believing something that isn't true. In other words, the mayor only feels as though the world is “topsy-turvy” because he has deceived himself into assuming Khlestakov is the government inspector, when Khlestakov isn't. Through self-deception, the mayor has caused himself to be disoriented, uncertain, and heedless of reality.

Act 4 Quotes

☛ This just isn't how things are done in a well-ordered community [...]. We should pay our respects one by one—*tête-à-tête* so to speak, behind closed doors, so no one sees or hears. That's how things are done in a well-ordered society.

Related Characters: Warden of Charities (speaker), Khlestakov

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 267

Explanation and Analysis

While the other town officials struggle to decide how to win Khlestakov's favor, the Warden of Charities proposes they each meet individually with the supposed government inspector “behind closed doors, so no one sees or hears.” He justifies his idea by saying, “That's how things are done in a well-ordered society.” According to the Warden of Charities, it's good, orderly, and proper for governments to operate through sly, secretive, and underhanded means. In his view, bribes are perfectly acceptable. When he suggests they “pay [their] respects” to Khlestakov, he means that they should visit Khlestakov out of politeness but also that they should literally pay their bribes to him during these individual meetings. It's also important to the Warden of Charities that these meetings occur “behind closed doors,” so that there's less transparency or accountability for the officials' actions. This creates more opportunities for dishonest dealings, which the Warden of Charities believes are perfectly appropriate. The Warden of Charities is so crooked that his understanding of a “well-ordered community” is entirely corrupted. But the confidence implied in his decisive speech indicates that he sees nothing wrong with his view of how governments should function. The other town officials see no problems either, and so they agree to the Warden of Charities' plan. By portraying the absurdity of such blatant corruption, the play satirizes corrupt government officials.

☛ After all, what does one really need? Only to be respected and genuinely liked.

Related Characters: Khlestakov (speaker), Postmaster

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 270

Explanation and Analysis

During a one-on-one meeting with the postmaster, Khlestakov professes that the only thing anyone “really need[s]” is “to be respected and genuinely liked.” This declaration suggests that Khlestakov believes genuine

respect and appreciation are most important—and, in fact, essential—in life. However, Khlestakov's actions throughout the play demonstrate that he actually seeks attention and admiration beyond what he deserves. Khlestakov repeatedly tries to appear more impressive than he is to attract other people's adoration. When Khlestakov exaggerates about who he is, he doesn't make genuine connections. Instead, he gains outside approval based on a false premise. Additionally, Khlestakov takes advantage of other people on numerous occasions for the sake of his own pleasure, which is neither particularly respectable nor likeable. In these situations, his selfish, pleasure-seeking impulses far outweigh his lofty aspirations for winning genuine respect from other people. Khlestakov craves external validation, but he does nothing to earn respect or positive recognition. The play encourages its audience to laugh at Khlestakov for believing that seeking outside approval is more important than doing good.

☝ She's quite a tasty dish too—not at all bad looking.

Related Characters: Khlestakov (speaker), The Mayor, Anna Andreyevna, Marya Antonovna

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 285

Explanation and Analysis

While he enjoys the mayor's hospitality, Khlestakov decides to take full advantage of his favorable circumstances and indulge his pleasure-seeking habits further. So, after Khlestakov flirts with the mayor's daughter, Marya Antonovna, he decides to flirt with her mother Anna Andreyevna too. Khlestakov thinks Anna is "not at all bad looking," which indicates that his interest in her is rather superficial and self-centered. Khlestakov shamelessly pursues Anna even though she's married to the mayor and he's already professed love to Marya. His unscrupulous advances toward both mother and daughter demonstrate that Khlestakov is irresponsible and frivolous when it comes to chasing after his desires. Khlestakov also calls Anna "quite a tasty dish." In doing so, Khlestakov phrases his attraction to women in the same terms as he does his admiration of delicious food. By comparing Anna—a woman whom he finds beautiful—to an appealing plate of food, Khlestakov confirms that food to him represents all the

different kinds of pleasure he selfishly pursues.

☝ What a dunderhead you are! Even when everything's been explained to you, you still don't believe it!

Related Characters: Anna Andreyevna (speaker), Khlestakov, The Mayor, Marya Antonovna

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 288

Explanation and Analysis

Anna Andreyevna becomes frustrated with her husband, the mayor, when he refuses to believe that Khlestakov wants to marry his daughter, even though she and Khlestakov both insist that it's true. Anna calls her husband "a dunderhead" and exclaims, "Even when everything's been explained to you, you still don't believe it!" Anna's words ring truer than she realizes. Throughout the play, the mayor consistently ignores the truth when it's right in front of him. He does so most crucially in the case of Khlestakov's identity. Even when Khlestakov truthfully explains who he is, the mayor doesn't believe him and continues to assume he's the government inspector. The mayor's rejection of obvious truths in favor of his own incorrect presumptions indeed reflects his stupidity. The double meaning of Anna's rebuke, which is apparent to the audience, points to the foolishness of the mayor's self-deception. Because the mayor sees only what is easiest to believe, he fails to notice aspects of reality that are evident to other people.

Act 5 Quotes

☝ Fish! I suppose that's all you can think of! But I do want to have the very best house in the Capital. There'll be such an exquisite odour when you enter my boudoir that it will make you close your eyes! Oh, how wonderful!

Related Characters: Anna Andreyevna (speaker), Khlestakov, The Mayor, Marya Antonovna

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 293

Explanation and Analysis

As soon as Anna Andreyevna and the mayor believe Khlestakov will marry their daughter, they assume this union will allow them to live extravagantly in St. Petersburg. Together, they fantasize about indulging in various luxuries. According to Anna, the mayor can only think about the kinds of fish he'll be able to enjoy. The mayor's wish for delicious fish demonstrates his greedy and simple-minded desire for material pleasures. In this way, food symbolizes greedy self-indulgence in pleasure, which the mayor frequently pursues. Anna criticizes her husband for his small-minded enthusiasm for fish, but she's equally materialistic and pleasure oriented. She wants "to have the very best house in the Capital." More specifically, she wants her boudoir to be filled with "an exquisite odour." Anna is also eager to indulge in material pleasures. By depicting Anna and the mayor as such shallow, avaricious people, the play satirizes human greed and selfishness.

Furthermore, Anna and the mayor believe their daughter's marriage to Khlestakov will launch them into polite society only because they've already deceived themselves that Khlestakov is a high-ranking government inspector who lives a decadent life. However, Anna and the mayor are mistaken about Khlestakov's identity. Since Khlestakov is only a low-ranking clerk and his engagement to Marya Antonovna was a hoax, Anna and the mayor's dreams are unlikely to come true. Their self-deception accentuates their foolishness and confirms that the mayor and his wife don't deserve the good fortune they incorrectly believe they've gained.

☞ What are you laughing at? You're laughing at yourselves, that's what!

Related Characters: The Mayor (speaker), Khlestakov

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 304

Explanation and Analysis

After the mayor discovers that Khlestakov is only a nobody—not the visiting government inspector he feared—the mayor furiously rebukes himself for being stupid and gullible. In the middle of his tirade, the mayor suddenly exclaims, "What are you laughing at? You're laughing at yourselves, that's what!" This abrupt line is usually directed toward the audience. In this way, the mayor breaks the fourth wall, or the imaginary separation between actors on stage and a play's viewers. When the mayor

directly addresses the audience, he berates them for laughing at him. The mayor's anger at being derided shows how much he cares about his reputation. He's loath to appear foolish because he only wants to be seen positively and craves external validation. However, the mayor clearly deserves mockery and contempt, not respect and admiration. The mayor is morally and politically corrupt, and his own selfishness, greed, and fear of getting caught for his extensive wrongdoings have led to his humiliation. The play encourages its audience to laugh at the mayor as it satirizes corrupt government officials and human vices.

However, when the mayor proclaims, "You're laughing at yourselves," he turns criticism toward the audience itself. He implies that audience members might be just as worthy of mockery for their own faults. In this way, the play suggests that the audience shouldn't only criticize the folly and immorality displayed on stage but also the folly and immorality that exists in the real world outside of theatrical drama. Beyond providing comedy in a fictional narrative, *The Government Inspector* also seeks to highlight and denounce flaws within 19th-century Russian society.

☞ Yes, they say those whom the gods want to punish they first drive insane. Was there anything *like* a government inspector about that whippersnapper? Absolutely damn all. Not by a long chalk!

Related Characters: The Mayor (speaker), Khlestakov

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 305

Explanation and Analysis

When the mayor realizes he has tricked himself into incorrectly believing Khlestakov is the government inspector, he reflects on his mistake. He says, "those whom the gods want to punish they first drive insane." This means that his self-deception feels like insanity, which he must be suffering as godsent punishment for his crimes. With this declaration, the mayor expresses how powerfully self-deception distorted his sense of truth and reality—so much so that it feels as if he lost his sanity.

Yet the mayor doesn't deflect all blame for his own error of judgement onto "the gods" or his temporary insanity. Instead, he recognizes how obvious the truth was—or should have been—all along. When he questions whether there was "anything *like* a government inspector" about

Khlestakov, he answers himself decisively: “Absolutely damn all. Not by a long chalk!” With these crucial words, the mayor himself admits that Khlestakov never really seemed like a government inspector at all. Khlestakov was always just a “whippersnapper,” or a young upstart. Only the mayor’s own insistent belief in false assumptions about Khlestakov made Khlestakov appear like the inspector. Thus, the mayor understands that he duped himself about Khlestakov’s identity and can only blame his own folly. As the mayor accepts that the negative consequences of his self-deception are his own fault, the mayor also implies that he deserves this retribution for his misdeeds as a corrupt government official. Not only the mayor’s folly but also his many vices have contributed to his rightful downfall.

“I can’t explain how it all came about, for the life of me. I feel as if a thick fog has blinded us. It’s the work of the devil!”

Related Characters: Warden of Charities (speaker), Khlestakov

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 305

Explanation and Analysis

After the town officials learn that Khlestakov wasn’t the government inspector after all, the Warden of Charities expresses shock that they were mistaken. He says he “can’t explain how it all came about,” and he feels “as if a thick fog has blinded” them. Here, the Warden of Charities

articulates how bewildering and disorienting their self-deception has been. Not only did the officials believe an incorrupt assumption about Khlestakov, but they also lost sight of the truth in a deeper way.

By doubling down on their mistaken perceptions of Khlestakov, the officials distorted reality for themselves, until the figurative “thick fog” of their self-deception “blinded” them—or obscured the truth. As a result, the officials were unable to view Khlestakov as anything but the government inspector, and they were wholly unaware of the possibility that they could be wrong. The depth of the officials’ misunderstanding demonstrates the power of self-deception. In fact, the play implies that self-deception can warp one’s sense of reality more thoroughly and dangerously than being deceived by someone else.

In addition to showcasing the perils of self-deception, these words also reveal that the Warden of Charities refuses to take responsibility for his error of judgment. First, he blames an almost supernatural “thick fog” for preventing himself and the other officials from seeing the truth. Then, he blames “the work of the devil.” In both cases, the Warden of Charities pins responsibility for the officials’ mistake on an external source of evil. However, in truth, the officials have only themselves to blame. Out of fear and foolishness, they duped themselves into believing Khlestakov was the government inspector. The Warden of Charities’ inability to recognize his own fault emphasizes the extent of his moral corruption. Even at the end of the play, when his guilt and folly are both undeniable, the Warden of Charities still doesn’t want to accept culpability.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

ACT 1

Scene 1. In a small Russian town, the mayor has assembled members of the local government in his house. He announces with dismay that an incognito government inspector from St. Petersburg will soon arrive to investigate them. The other men are alarmed. The mayor says he had a premonition of this situation last night, when he dreamed about enormous rats in the town. The mayor explains he received warning of the government inspector from a trusted relative, who wanted the mayor to be able to cover up the “odd little peccadillo” before the inspector’s arrival.

In the Russian Empire at this time (the 1830s), a government inspector’s job was to report on corruption and inefficiency in the provinces. So, the town officials’ fear of being investigated indicates that they’re guilty of wrongdoings they’d prefer to keep covered up. From the outset, then, it’s clear that political corruption is pervasive in this town. If it’s common knowledge that the mayor commits minor crimes every now and then, there are likely larger problems with the local government as well. It’s ironic that the mayor views the rumored government inspector as a rat, when he’s the real “rat” for his dishonest and immoral behavior.



The judge worries that the inspector’s visit means that Russia is going to war and the government is looking for traitors. The mayor rebukes him for jumping to ridiculous conclusions. Then the mayor instructs the Warden of Charities to make the charity hospital look presentable, so the inspector doesn’t think it’s poorly run. The mayor asks the judge—who openly admits to taking bribes—to clean up the courthouse, and he tells the Inspector of Schools to better control the teachers, who might offend the inspector with subversive ideas. The mayor fears he and his fellow officials will suddenly be caught in their misconduct.

The judge doesn’t see how he and the other town officials are at fault, so he overlooks the obvious reason for the inspector’s visit—their own blatant corruption—and speculates wildly instead. However, it’s plain that all the officials poorly manage the town’s institutions to the townspeople’s detriment. The judge himself cares more about his own pleasure than duty, which is why he’s so eager to take bribes. Importantly, the mayor doesn’t actually want to improve the local government: he only wants to hide evidence of corruption temporarily so the officials won’t get into trouble. The mayor’s panicked scrambling to look good in front of the inspector is comically futile, considering how extensive his maladministration is.



Scene 2. The postmaster enters. Already aware of the news about the government inspector, he exclaims that Russia must be going to war. Again, the mayor dismisses that foolish idea and reminds everyone that they are the ones in trouble. The mayor asks the postmaster to open all letters to find out if anyone has informed on him. The postmaster, who always reads people’s mail out of curiosity, promises to detain any letters complaining about the town’s governance. The judge warns they’ll get into trouble for intercepting letters, but the mayor says they’ll keep it secret.

Once again, the postmaster displays the town officials’ tendency to look anywhere but at their own faults when he blames the inspector’s visit on an imaginary war. Also, like the other officials, the postmaster is foolishly incompetent at his duty. He prioritizes his own simple-minded pleasure over performing his job properly. Instead of reprimanding the postmaster, the mayor encourages the postmaster’s crimes in order to protect himself, which further proves the mayor’s corruption.



Scene 3. Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky arrive in a rush with astonishing news. Constantly interrupting each other, they reveal that when they stopped at the inn to eat earlier, they saw a young official from St. Petersburg there. Despite being on his way to Saratov province, this official named Khlestakov has been staying in the inn for two weeks. Bobchinsky declares that Khlestakov must be the government inspector. The mayor is terrified that the inspector has already arrived and resolves to go to the inn to smooth things over with him. As the officials leave, the Warden of Charities worries the inspector will discover that the charity hospital patients aren't being fed properly.

Scene 4. The constable Svistunov has prepared a carriage for the mayor. The other constable the mayor summoned is absent because he's drunk and unfit for duty. Distressed, the mayor complains that his **sword** is scratched and blames the shopkeeper Abdulin for not sending him a new one. He orders Svistunov to clean the streets around the inn and chastises him for taking bribes above his rank.

Scene 5. The mayor orders the Chief of Police to station constables around town to make a good impression. Accidentally putting a box on his head instead of a hat, the mayor prays to God for help, promising to bully shopkeepers for enough wax to light an enormous candle in church. The mayor also tells the Chief of Police to correct the misbehavior of the constables and soldiers.

Although Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky identify Khlestakov as the government inspector without sure evidence, the town officials believe them without question. The officials' fear of the inspector is strong enough to convince them that the inspector is indeed already here. As a result, the corrupt officials immediately focus on winning Khlestakov over and concealing their considerable misdeeds from him rather than first confirming whether Khlestakov is really the inspector or not.



The mayor's damaged sword symbolizes both the mayor's authority, which is tarnished by his immorality, and the town's wider political corruption, which the mayor enables. Instead of recognizing his responsibility for the town's poor administration, the mayor blames other people's disloyalty. Additionally, the mayor's interaction with Svistunov reveals the corruption of the police as well. The mayor isn't concerned that constables abuse their power—he's only concerned that constables take too much from townspeople, leaving little for higher-ranking officials to steal. Finally, the mayor's request for the constables to clean only around the inn where the inspector is supposedly staying demonstrates the mayor's resistance to making any substantial improvements to the town. He'll only make superficial changes for appearance's sake to avoid being caught by the inspector.



Again, the mayor wants to look like a good mayor without actually performing his duties well. Only as an afterthought does the mayor suggest that the Chief of Police should better control the disorderly and violent constables. The police's misconduct and the mayor's indifference both testify to the town's widespread corruption that can't be hidden by superficial measures. While the mayor carries himself seriously, he's portrayed as a foolish bully. The audience is encouraged to laugh at the mayor's stupidity and to be unsympathetic when the mayor prays for help, since his sincerity is undermined by his intention to keep bullying townspeople.



Scene 6. Anna Andreyevna shouts for her husband, the mayor. She reproaches her daughter, Marya Antonovna, for vainly fussing about her appearance and wasting time, then queries about the government inspector's looks and rank. The mayor promises to answer her later and departs. Anna Andreyevna irritably shouts at the housekeeper to chase after the mayor's carriage and find out about the inspector.

Once the town officials believe Khlestakov is the government inspector, everyone around them also believes it and gets drawn into the excitement surrounding the inspector's presence. Anna Andreyevna's demands to know all about the inspector are self-centered and also hypocritical. Anna scorns her daughter's vanity, but she herself cares mostly about the inspector's appearance and social status, which reveals her own vanity and shallowness.



ACT 2

Scene 1. In a room at the inn, Khlestakov's servant Osip lies in bed and grumbles about how hungry he is. Khlestakov—who is nobody but a minor clerk—has spent all his money irresponsibly on the road, and now they're stranded without funds. Osip reminisces happily about life in St. Petersburg, where people are polite and always call him "sir." He complains that Khlestakov wastes money taking cabs around the city and playing cards instead of doing honest work.

Khlestakov—who is notably not a government inspector—represents the inefficacy of the Russian Empire's bureaucracy. Khlestakov has a rank and government position in St. Petersburg, but his only importance lies in his title. He wields no actual power, and he hardly possesses any sense of diligence or duty. Instead, motivated entirely by pleasure, Khlestakov spends all his time chasing easy excitement and comfort from gambling, entertainment, and good food. Osip is more responsible and practical than Khlestakov, but even Osip appreciates the pleasure of being treated as a gentleman in St. Petersburg. Although they both wish to enjoy luxuries usually reserved for much higher-ranking people, Osip is only a servant and Khlestakov a petty official.



Scene 2. Khlestakov enters and rebukes Osip for lying in bed. Then he begs Osip to ask the landlord for **lunch**. Osip refuses, reminding Khlestakov that the landlord has sworn not to give them any more food. Khlestakov has been charging expenses to his account rather than paying upfront, and now the landlord suspects they won't ever pay their bill. The landlord has threatened to get them thrown in jail. Khlestakov angrily sends Osip to fetch the landlord anyway.

Khlestakov's petulant demands for a meal show how important food is to him. For Khlestakov, food represents the pleasure he constantly, self-indulgently seeks. So, lacking food doesn't just mean that Khlestakov is hungry—it also means that his life is currently missing all the kinds of pleasure he craves. However, Khlestakov knows he can't pay, yet he still thinks he's entitled to good food. His desire for pleasure leads him to try to cheat people to satisfy his wants, and he rudely bosses other people around until he gets what he doesn't actually deserve. By taking advantage of what little authority he has, Khlestakov tries to fulfill his own pleasure selfishly at other people's expense.



Scene 3. Alone and starving, Khlestakov regrets losing all his money to an infantry captain in a game of cards, but he wishes he could play a second game.

Khlestakov is still eager to pursue pleasure, even though pleasure-seeking is the reason why he's out of money, stranded, and famished in the first place. Focusing on self-gratification makes Khlestakov short-sighted and foolish.



Scene 4. Osip returns with a waiter. Khlestakov demands to have lunch so he can return to his important business. The waiter says the landlord has refused to serve Khlestakov anymore and plans to complain to the mayor about him. Khlestakov insists the waiter should try to change the landlord's mind. The waiter acquiesces and leaves.

By claiming to have important business, Khlestakov tries to portray himself as more distinguished than he actually is. He wants to reap the benefits of seeming like a hardworking person of high status even though he's a nobody and often avoids hard work. Khlestakov's dishonesty emphasizes how undignified his situation really is.



Scene 5. Khlestakov wonders if he might have to sell some of his clothes. He fantasizes about driving home in a carriage and causing a commotion as people speculate about who he must be. He imagines being formally announced by a footman and wooing someone's daughter.

That Khlestakov would rather contemplate selling his possessions for money than be more responsible with his finances demonstrates Khlestakov's lightmindedness. Also, Khlestakov's daydream conveys that in addition to pleasure, Khlestakov strongly desires external validation. He wants other people to admire him, and he longs for the respect and attention that his society affords to important, high-ranking men.



Scene 6. Osip and the waiter return with a small **lunch**. Between mouthfuls, Khlestakov protests that the food is too meager and disgusting; nevertheless, he finishes it quickly. He asks for more food but is denied.

Khlestakov continues to act arrogantly, as if he were a prestigious person. However, his imperious attitude is comically undermined by the fact that he eats all the food anyway and even asks for more. This meal signifies that Khlestakov is greedy for the highest pleasures and will insult people who refuse him his desires, but he won't deny simpler pleasures either.



Scene 7. Osip informs Khlestakov that the mayor is inquiring about him downstairs. Khlestakov panics, thinking that the mayor will throw him in jail. To gather his courage, he tells himself that he's not a common workman and simply won't go to jail.

Khlestakov decides that if he asserts himself as a powerful authority figure, he'll be able to stand up to the mayor and avoid punishment for cheating the innkeeper. By trying to put on airs, Khlestakov emphasizes how loath he is to be perceived as an ordinary, low-ranking person. He desperately wants others to treat him as an important person, even though he isn't one, so he can pursue pleasures as he desires without facing negative consequences.



Scene 8. The mayor and Khlestakov stare at each other in mutual terror. Finally, the mayor, believing that Khlestakov is the government inspector, greets Khlestakov and offers him different accommodations. Upset, Khlestakov promises to pay his bill and refuses to go to jail. The frightened mayor suddenly admits to taking bribes but claims that other charges against him are slander. Khlestakov is confused and truthfully confesses he has no money, but the mayor assumes Khlestakov is lying to cover up his identity as the inspector. The mayor gives Khlestakov money.

Reassured by the mayor's "loan" and vows of generosity, Khlestakov speaks with the mayor readily and honestly. However, the mayor is convinced Khlestakov is a wily liar. The mayor offers to host Khlestakov in his own house. Delighted, Khlestakov accepts, thanks the mayor for being sincere and cordial, and says all he asks for in life is "devotion and respect, respect and devotion."

Scene 9. Khlestakov calls the waiter so he can pay his bill, but the mayor promises that the payment will be taken care of for him.

Scene 10. The mayor invites Khlestakov to inspect the local institutions. Khlestakov doesn't understand why but accepts. On Khlestakov's dining bill, the mayor hastily writes a message for his wife and gives the note to Dobchinsky to deliver. Meanwhile, the mayor plans to get Khlestakov drunk so he can learn what Khlestakov must be hiding. Suddenly, the door crashes to the floor and Bobchinsky, who was hiding and eavesdropping, falls to the ground. The mayor tells Osip to bring Khlestakov's luggage to the mayor's house and scolds Bobchinsky.

Khlestakov's mistaken identity has humorous repercussions. First, it leads the mayor to confess some of his guilt as a corrupt official while simultaneously trying to protect his image. As a result, the mayor only appears more foolish and crooked than before. Second, the mayor bribes Khlestakov, which comically undermines his claims to be an honest government official. The mayor's readiness to buy Khlestakov's favor proves his corruption and preoccupation with self-preservation. Crucially, Khlestakov isn't aware that the mayor thinks he's a government inspector. Yet his blustering inadvertently convinces the mayor further that he is the inspector. Even when Khlestakov tells the truth, the mayor doesn't believe him and continues to think Khlestakov is the inspector.



By being suspicious of Khlestakov and doubling down on his belief that Khlestakov is the inspector, the mayor thinks he's being clever and discerning. However, in actuality, the mayor is foolishly ignoring reality at his own expense. Even when faced with the truth, the mayor refuses to reconsider his assumptions about Khlestakov. Meanwhile, Khlestakov rejoices that he's found both pleasure and external validation in the mayor's generosity. He's enlivened by the mayor's money, hospitality, and eagerness to flatter and please. Ironically, he appreciates the mayor's sincerity, when in fact Khlestakov is the only honest person in this situation.



The mayor seeks to win Khlestakov's favor by being generous and forgiving so that he won't get into trouble with the supposed government inspector. The mayor is only kind when it benefits him, demonstrating his selfishness and twisted morals.



The mayor's underhanded scheme to gain power over the supposed government inspector showcases the mayor's immorality. Moreover, his shamelessness about tricking Khlestakov demonstrates that he doesn't see his actions as wrong. If the mayor appears at all cunning, the slapstick comedy of Bobchinsky's fall undercuts any sense of the mayor's or his acquaintances' intelligence. By having to chide Bobchinsky, the mayor is once again portrayed in a foolish light.



ACT 3

Scene 1. In the mayor's house, Anna Andreyevna and Marya Antonovna await news about the government inspector. As her mother endlessly criticizes her, Marya notices Dobchinsky approaching the house. When Anna finally accepts that her daughter's observation is correct, she futilely tries to question Dobchinsky from the window.

Anna Andreyevna's eagerness to hear about the supposed government inspector exemplifies how quickly town residents believe Khlestakov is the inspector based on hearsay. As Anna demands impatiently to know everything about Khlestakov, she reveals her self-centeredness. She must always be at the center of excitement. She also haughtily refuses to admit when she's wrong. That Anna hates to be corrected yet makes obvious mistakes makes her seem more ridiculous.



Scene 2. Dobchinsky gives Anna Andreyevna the note from the mayor, and she asks what kind of man the government inspector is. Dobchinsky says Khlestakov is as good as a general—cultured, dignified, and intimidating. After inquiring about the inspector's age and looks, Anna reads the mayor's note. At first, she's bewildered by her husband's words, which are interrupted by the text of Khlestakov's dining bill. But she makes sense of it and instructs the mayor's servant Mishka to prepare for Khlestakov's stay.

Dobchinsky's description of Khlestakov is evidence of his self-deception. Dobchinsky views Khlestakov as impressive and frightening only because he's already assumed that Khlestakov is the government inspector. Instead of seeing Khlestakov for who he really is, Dobchinsky perceives him according to his inaccurate, preconceived notions. Then Dobchinsky shares his misunderstanding of Khlestakov with Anna Andreyevna and Marya Antonovna, causing them to form their own mistaken assumptions about Khlestakov. Anna's view of Khlestakov is particularly shallow, as she only cares if he's high-ranking and handsome.



Scene 3. Anna Andreyevna and Marya Antonovna debate about what to wear to impress the inspector. Anna compares herself to the Queen of Clubs, but Marya says she's more like the Queen of Hearts.

When Anna Andreyevna insists on impressing Khlestakov with her appearance, she reveals her need for praise and admiration from other people. Her desire for approval from Khlestakov in particular stems from her belief that Khlestakov is an important person whose attention is especially valuable. Anna wants to associate herself with powerful people. However, Khlestakov isn't actually a government inspector, as she thinks he is. Anna's allusion to the Queen of Clubs also demonstrates her vanity and self-centeredness. In the card game solitaire, the Queen of Clubs was thought to predict a woman's marriage. Therefore, when Anna likens herself to the Queen of Clubs, she gloats about her own desirability.



Scene 4. Osip brings Khlestakov's luggage into the mayor's house, and Mishka asks him about his master. Osip answers that Khlestakov is "a general, but bottom side up," which, he says, is more than a real general. Osip asks for some food, then he and Mishka carry Khlestakov's suitcase into his room.

When Osip calls Khlestakov "a general, but bottom side up," he means that Khlestakov isn't a general at all. In fact, Khlestakov is the opposite of a general: a civil servant of the lowest rank. When Osip jokes further that Khlestakov is more than a real general, he implies that real generals aren't worth their titles. This suggests that—at least from Osip's perspective—high-ranking government officials don't deserve the prestige their social status carries. Here, Osip also mocks Khlestakov's tendency to show off and act superior as if he's more important than a real general.



Scene 5. Khlestakov arrives at the mayor's house, pleased by the local officials' hospitality and the **delicious lunch** he ate at the charity hospital. The Warden of Charities brags about the hospital's management, and the mayor boasts about his demanding duties and humble diligence. When Khlestakov asks if the town has any playing-card societies, the mayor exaggeratedly denies any interest in cards. In an aside, the judge reveals that the mayor won money in a card game against him just last night.

Khlestakov's fixation on food emphasizes that his priority is pursuing pleasure. Likewise, the food from the charity hospital lunch symbolizes Khlestakov's self-indulgent pleasure seeking. The food also represents the town officials' selfishness and greed, especially as the officials get to enjoy the delicious lunch for their own benefit in the same place where hospital patients suffer as a result of the officials' dereliction of duty. Preoccupied with his own pleasure, Khlestakov doesn't notice the obvious signs of the officials' corruption, that he's being bribed, or that he's been mistaken as a government inspector. He simply seeks more pleasure. Meanwhile, the judge exposes more of the mayor's lies, corruption, and avarice through his jealousy.



Scene 6. The mayor introduces his wife and daughter to Khlestakov, who compliments and flatters Anna Andreyevna. Khlestakov begins overstating his importance in the civil service. He says he was once mistaken for the Commander-in-Chief. He also says he's a brilliant author and gives extravagant balls in St. Petersburg. He claims he was once begged to take charge of a whole government department, and that he visits the imperial palace every day. Terrified, the mayor suggests that Khlestakov rest in his room.

Khlestakov continues to take advantage of the officials' eagerness to please him. For his own frivolous enjoyment, he flirts with the mayor's wife and boasts about the fictitious, grandiose life he lives. Importantly, Khlestakov isn't trying intentionally to frighten and deceive the officials into believing how powerful he is as a government inspector. Instead, his fundamental desires for pleasure and external validation lead him to exaggerate his social status simply for the officials' attention and admiration. However, the officials have already convinced themselves that Khlestakov is the inspector, so his ridiculous claims seem like terrifying threats to them. They fear they may be in trouble with much higher-ranking authorities than they initially thought.



Scene 7. Bobchinsky declares he almost died of fright in Khlestakov's presence. Bobchinsky thinks Khlestakov's rank must be even higher than general. Nervously, the Warden of Charities hopes that Khlestakov won't write any reports to St. Petersburg.

The town officials continue to deceive themselves into thinking Khlestakov is an intimidating, powerful, high-ranking government inspector based on the assumptions they've already made about him. Their enduring mistake about Khlestakov's identity reflects their comic foolishness. Additionally, the officials' fear indicates how guilty of corruption they are. They wouldn't be so afraid of Khlestakov if they weren't trying to conceal so many of their misdeeds from him.



Scene 8. Anna Andreyevna and Marya Antonovna gush over Khlestakov's charm and argue which one of them Khlestakov looked at the most.

Anna Andreyevna and Marya Antonovna's captivation with Khlestakov is not only superficial and self-centered—it's also disproportionate, considering that Khlestakov isn't actually the high-status, dignified personage they believe he is. Also, Anna's bickering with Marya demonstrates that Anna is willing to be rude and competitive against her own daughter in order to be the sole center of attention. This emphasizes Anna's strong desire for external validation.



Scene 9. The mayor hushes everyone so they don't disturb Khlestakov. The mayor admits Khlestakov was very drunk and must have embellished some of his stories, but the mayor doesn't know what's true anymore. He says, "The whole world's gone topsy-turvy," because it seems that Khlestakov may be a far more important person than he initially appeared.

As he convinces himself to believe in and fear Khlestakov's identity as the government inspector, the mayor distances himself further from reality. He worries he can no longer separate truth from fiction and feels as if the world itself has become distorted. The mayor's reaction suggests how powerfully disorienting self-deception can be.



Scene 10. Interrupting each other, Anna Andreyevna and the mayor question Osip about Khlestakov's rank and personality. Osip answers vaguely so he doesn't contradict their impression of Khlestakov as a very important person. When the mayor asks what Khlestakov enjoys most while traveling, Osip says Khlestakov appreciates hospitality and good **food**. The mayor gives Osip money and in annoyance sends his wife and daughter away.

The mayor's efforts to find out more about Khlestakov through bribery exemplifies how underhanded the corrupt mayor's dealings often are. That Osip accepts the mayor's bribes shows that Osip isn't much more scrupulous about how he fulfills his desires for comfort and ease than Khlestakov or the town officials. Also, for his own pleasure and convenience, Osip allows the mayor and Anna Andreyevna to believe what they've already persuaded themselves is true about Khlestakov. Even so, Osip is more honest than deceptive. He's truthful about Khlestakov's personality and love of food, for instance, indirectly hinting at Khlestakov's desire for pleasure above all else.



Scene 11. Two constables arrive at the mayor's house. The mayor commands them to guard the front door and turn away any petitioners by force.

The mayor's readiness to use violence against townspeople provides another clear example of how the mayor wrongfully abuses his power and harms the citizens he governs. Furthermore, by trying to prevent townspeople from reporting his misdeeds to Khlestakov, the mayor reveals his desperation to hide his corruption in order to protect himself. The mayor is not only corrupt but also cowardly and selfish. The play criticizes corrupt government officials through the example of the morally reprehensible mayor.



ACT 4

Scene 1. In the mayor's house, the town officials try to get into formation so they can appear orderly before Khlestakov. They wonder how to bribe him without being too obvious. The Warden of Charities suggests they speak to Khlestakov one by one. They beg the judge to go first, not wanting to do it themselves. Coughs from Khlestakov's room send them scrambling out, panicking and colliding together.

The town officials' desperation to avoid getting caught for their misdeeds shows how guilty of corruption they are. Their morals are so distorted that they care only about self-preservation. Moreover, they can only think of using corrupt methods—namely, bribery and secretive meetings—to protect themselves. Additionally, the officials' fear of Khlestakov illustrates how thoroughly they've deceived themselves into believing that Khlestakov is the government inspector. The comedy of the corrupt officials' nervous, bumbling stupidity encourages the audience to ridicule and disdain them.



Scene 2. Khlestakov wakes up with a headache. He's eager to enjoy the mayor's hospitality and expresses interest in both the mayor's daughter and wife.

Khlestakov's single-minded purpose is to experience as much pleasure as he can. His shameless opportunism emphasizes how shallow, greedy, and self-centered his pursuits of pleasure are.



Scene 3. The judge enters nervously and introduces himself to Khlestakov. He becomes flustered and drops money on the floor. Khlestakov notices, and the judge fears he'll be taken away to prison. But Khlestakov asks to keep the money as a loan, because he's short on funds. The judge hurriedly agrees. Khlestakov has no instructions for the district court, so the judge believes he's saved.

Khlestakov further demonstrates his greed and selfishness when he takes the judge's money as a loan he doesn't intend to repay. Without realizing that he's being bribed as the government inspector, Khlestakov takes advantage of the judge for the sake of his own pleasure. Meanwhile, the judge foolishly feels relieved that his misdeeds have been forgiven. However, in actuality, the judge has neither won over the inspector nor gained anything by meeting with Khlestakov. Instead, he has only lost money to an opportunistic stranger.



Scene 4. Next, the postmaster introduces himself. During their conversation, Khlestakov says all anyone needs is to be "respected and genuinely liked." Then Khlestakov asks for and receives a loan, so he won't have to deny himself anything while traveling.

Khlestakov makes the most of another meeting with a town official by asking for more money to fund his frivolous pleasure-seeking. He reiterates his demand for comfort and ease, as well as his need for external validation through being liked and respected by other people. Notably, Khlestakov's own moral corruption is evident in his willingness to cheat other people for his selfish gain. Moreover, Khlestakov clearly desires more respect and admiration than he deserves.



Scene 5. The Inspector of Schools is pushed into the room and introduces himself nervously. Khlestakov offers him a cigar, but the Inspector of Schools drops it out of fear. Khlestakov asks if he prefers blonde or brunette women, but he's too afraid to answer. Then Khlestakov asks for a loan. The Inspector of Schools hands over the money and leaves, hoping that Khlestakov won't inspect the schools now.

Khlestakov continues to indulge in all the pleasures available to him. He enjoys more amusement and money, while the Inspector of Schools gains nothing. The town officials' attempts at self-preservation are ineffective because they fail to bribe a real government inspector. By persuading themselves that Khlestakov has power over them, the officials have led themselves to be swindled. However, they still don't realize their mistake, and they're foolishly hopeful they can get away with their corruption.



Scene 6. The Warden of Charities enters. Khlestakov compliments the lunch they ate at the charity hospital, confessing that good **food** is his weakness. The Warden of Charities professes his desire to serve his country diligently, then exposes the other officials' misconduct. He reveals the postmaster barely does his duties and that the judge spends all his time hunting, possesses terrible morals, and is carrying on an affair with Dobchinsky's wife. He adds that the Inspector of Schools teaches subversive ideas. Khlestakov asks for this information to be put into writing for light reading when he gets bored, then asks for a loan.

That Khlestakov remembers the Warden of Charities only by the delicious food they ate at the charity hospital emphasizes Khlestakov's preoccupation with pleasure. Also, Khlestakov's disinterest in the town officials' crimes showcases his self-centeredness. Khlestakov treats the Warden of Charities' revelations as mere entertainment for his own enjoyment, rather than crucial evidence of serious problems. Although Khlestakov isn't a government inspector, he's still a member of the civil service, yet he doesn't care about local corruption. Khlestakov's lack of concern shows that he's a bad government official. Additionally, the Warden of Charities appears particularly corrupt, as he's the only official willing to betray the others to ingratiate himself with the supposed inspector.



Scene 7. Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky introduce themselves to Khlestakov. At once, Khlestakov asks for money, and they give him all 65 rubles they have. Dobchinsky asks for Khlestakov's advice about his eldest, illegitimate son. Khlestakov vaguely agrees to put in a good word for him somewhere and also promises to mention Bobchinsky's name to high-ranking people when he returns to St. Petersburg.

By taking money even from Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky, Khlestakov displays selfishness and greed. In this case, he's also taking advantage of citizens rather than fellow corrupt government officials, highlighting how Khlestakov too abuses power at townspeople's expense. Furthermore, Khlestakov only agrees to do favors for Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky because he wants to appear important and high ranking. He knows he has no real authority to fulfill their requests, but he desires their respect and admiration. In this way, Khlestakov seeks outside approval beyond what he deserves.



Scene 8. Alone, Khlestakov realizes now that the town officials have mistaken him for someone more important than he actually is. He decides to write to his friend in St. Petersburg about them, so they can be lampooned in the newspaper. Khlestakov happily counts up the money they gave him and hopes for a second game with the infantry captain to whom he lost his money gambling before.

Once Khlestakov finally realizes that he's been taken for someone else, he ridicules the town officials' stupidity. His laughter highlights the ridiculousness of their mistake. Because the officials have deceived themselves so thoroughly about Khlestakov's identity, they've lost some of their money and their dignity. Meanwhile, Khlestakov is delighted that they've treated him so well. He exhibits more of his greedy and self-centered desire for pleasure as he looks forward to future gambling.



Scene 9. Osip urges Khlestakov to leave town while things are still going well for him. Khlestakov reluctantly agrees and finishes his letter to his friend in St. Petersburg. From the window, they hear petitioners who want to see Khlestakov. Although the constables are trying to keep them out, Khlestakov tells Osip to let them in.

Khlestakov's reluctance to leave town demonstrates his incessant desire for pleasure. He wants to continue enjoying himself as much as possible by taking advantage of the foolish, corrupt local officials. Even when Khlestakov allows petitioners to approach him, he's acting on selfish impulses. He has no power to help them—he simply wants entertainment and external validation from townspeople who believe he's an important authority figure.



Scene 10. Shopkeepers beg Khlestakov to save them from the mayor, who takes anything he wants from shops without paying and threatens to torture townspeople if they complain. Khlestakov is scandalized by this news. The shopkeepers offer him **sugar and wine**, which Khlestakov at first refuses, because he doesn't take bribes. However, Khlestakov accepts money from them as a loan, and Osip takes the sugar and wine anyway. Khlestakov promises to do everything he can to help the shopkeepers.

When the shopkeepers expose more of the mayor's misdeeds, Khlestakov acknowledges how terribly corrupt and immoral the mayor is. However, even though Khlestakov may not be as crooked as the mayor, he still isn't a good government official. He steals money from the shopkeepers, and he allows Osip to accept luxurious food items as bribes. Neither Osip nor Khlestakov can resist food, which symbolizes pleasure and self-indulgence. Worse, Khlestakov knows he's only a clerk, has no real governmental power, and can't actually help the shopkeepers. Khlestakov makes false promises to them only so he can look more impressive.



Scene 11. The locksmith's wife and the sergeant's widow petition Khlestakov next. The locksmith's wife complains that the mayor sent her husband to the army prematurely and illegally. The sergeant's widow complains that she was flogged without reason. Khlestakov agrees to ensure that the mayor is fined. Sick of seeing petitioners, he sends the rest away.

The locksmith's wife and sergeant's widow seem to have legitimate complaints about the mayor's extensive corruption, but as soon as the petitioners stop being entertaining to Khlestakov and start being troublesome, Khlestakov loses interest. He doesn't care about their lives. He's only concerned with his own pleasure. Khlestakov's apathy toward problems with the local government demonstrates his self-centeredness and corruption as a negligent bureaucrat.



Scene 12. Khlestakov meets Marya Antonovna and begins flirting with her. Marya resists his compliments, but she asks him to write some verses of poetry in her album. Khlestakov boasts that he knows so many poems but can't remember any. He declares his love for her and kisses her shoulder. When Marya grows upset at his impertinence and starts to leave, Khlestakov begs for forgiveness on his knees.

Khlestakov flirts with the mayor's daughter for his own selfish pleasure. His interest in Marya Antonovna is purely superficial, and his advances are impudently flippant. To a certain extent, Marya is charmed by Khlestakov's city manners because she believes he's an important, high-ranking man. But Marya isn't immediately enamored with him, showing that Khlestakov isn't very impressive after all. Khlestakov's failure to be romantic enhances the comedy of this scene. While confessing his love melodramatically, Khlestakov seems more like a ridiculous fool than an alluring gentleman.



Scene 13. Anna Andreyevna walks in, shocked. She scolds her daughter and sends her away angrily. Khlestakov declares his love again, and Anna thinks he wants to propose to her daughter, but Khlestakov proclaims that it is Anna whom he loves. She protests that she's married, but Khlestakov doesn't care.

Khlestakov indulges frivolously in any pleasure he can find, even if it's inappropriate to pursue a married woman and her daughter at the same time. Khlestakov's shamelessness emphasizes his greed and self-centeredness, which are made more humorous by his exaggerated displays of sincerity. The play presents Khlestakov as a ridiculous figure and mocks him for being so fixated on pleasure.



Scene 14. Marya Antonovna returns and is shocked to see Khlestakov kneeling before her mother. Anna Andreyevna chastises her tearful daughter. Then Khlestakov takes Marya's hand and asks for a blessing for *their* love. Anna tells her daughter she's unworthy of a man like Khlestakov, and Marya apologizes earnestly.

Khlestakov insists on having Marya Antonovna's hand in marriage, even though now he understands he's been mistaken for someone else and has made plans to leave town imminently. This false engagement shows that Khlestakov does whatever is pleasurable and entertaining for himself in the moment, without thinking of future consequences or the impact his actions have on other people. Khlestakov is irresponsibly self-indulgent. Additionally, Anna Andreyevna's thorough self-deception is evident in how she talks about Khlestakov. She already believes Khlestakov is a highly prestigious person, so she aggrandizes him in her mind to an unreasonable extent.



Scene 15. The mayor implores Khlestakov not to ruin him, swearing that the shopkeepers are liars. Khlestakov doesn't care about the shopkeepers anymore. Anna Andreyevna tells her husband that Khlestakov has asked to marry their daughter. The mayor doesn't believe this and agonizes over his fate, despite Khlestakov's and Anna's insistence about the engagement. Finally, the mayor gives his blessing. Seeing Khlestakov kiss his daughter, the mayor finally believes the engagement is real and rejoices.

The mayor's pathetic attempts to cover up his misdeeds by lying and accusing the shopkeepers of deceit reinforce how corrupt he is. Meanwhile, Khlestakov's dismissal of the shopkeepers showcases his indifference to the town's corruption and, instead, his sole focus on self-gratification. Khlestakov is so consumed by his desire for pleasure that he ignores his duties as a civil servant and enables corrupt government officials to commit crimes without care. Similarly, the mayor is so absorbed in his fears of getting caught by the government inspector that he's unable to recognize obvious truths. He continues to believe Khlestakov is the inspector and foolishly believes that Khlestakov's supposed engagement to his daughter absolves him of his misconduct.



Scene 16. Osip informs Khlestakov that the horses are ready for his departure. Khlestakov claims he'll return tomorrow, borrows even more money from the mayor, and says farewell. Offstage, the mayor expresses surprise that Khlestakov is riding in such a worn-down carriage, and the housekeeper brings a Persian rug for Khlestakov to sit on. Khlestakov departs.

Khlestakov successfully gets away from the town officials before they discover he's not a government inspector. He even manages to escape with yet another bribe from the corrupt mayor—or, what Khlestakov believes is a generous “loan.” Even when the mayor sees the rickety carriage Khlestakov has hired—proof that Khlestakov really is a nobody—the mayor still doesn't recognize his mistake. Instead, the self-deceived mayor foolishly continues to treat Khlestakov like royalty.



ACT 5

Scene 1. The mayor and his wife celebrate their daughter's engagement to Khlestakov, which they expect will also raise them to higher rank and status. The mayor believes he could even become a general. They imagine moving to St. Petersburg, mixing with aristocrats, and enjoying expensive luxuries.

As the mayor and Anna Andreyevna imagine how they'll benefit from their daughter's marriage, they reveal their selfishness and greed. They fantasize about holding prestigious titles and showing off to other people, which demonstrates their craving for external validation. Also, their excitement for material luxuries exemplifies their desire for self-indulgent pleasure-seeking. The mayor and his wife's daydreams are ridiculous because they're overambitious, but also because they're based on the false belief that Khlestakov is a preeminent government inspector who actually intends to marry their daughter. Because they can't see the truth, the mayor and his wife foolishly aspire to greatness, which they don't deserve.



Scene 2. The shopkeepers present themselves to the mayor after being summoned by a constable. The mayor curses them and calls them double-dealing crooks for complaining to Khlestakov about him. The shopkeepers accept guilt and entreat the mayor not to ruin them. The mayor won't bear a grudge but asks to be properly congratulated for his daughter's marriage.

The mayor's verbal abuse of the shopkeepers showcases how the mayor abuses his authority to insult and belittle other people. The mayor is an example of not only political corruption but also moral corruption. Moreover, when the mayor demands proper congratulations from the shopkeepers, he exposes his need to receive other people's admiration so he can feel superior. He also means that he wants more extravagant bribes from them than he normally receives, which exemplifies his selfish greed for materialistic pleasure.



Scene 3. The judge, Warden of Charities, and a town citizen named Rastakovsky all congratulate the mayor's good fortune. They kiss Anna Andreyevna's and Marya Antonovna's hands.

Once everyone believes the mayor's daughter will soon marry Khlestakov—the purported high-ranking government inspector—town officials and citizens rush to flatter the mayor with gracious well wishes. Their congratulations fulfill the mayor's desire for respect and admiration, even though the mayor hasn't done anything himself to earn such positive recognition.



Scene 4. Three more citizens—Korobkin, Korobkin's wife, and Lyulyukov—congratulate the mayor, Anna Andreyevna, and Marya Antonovna.

Town citizens seek to present themselves in a good light to the mayor by being courteous and friendly, since flattering the mayor will also enhance their own reputations for graciousness and respectability. In this way, they seek their own external validation from the mayor and his family.



Scene 5. From a crowd of well-wishers, Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky push their way to the mayor and his family. Talking over each other, they offer their congratulations and wish Marya Antonovna a happy wedding, wealth, and a tiny baby boy.

As a whole host of townspeople congratulate the mayor and his family, the mayor gets his wish for other people's approval and adoration, which increases his self-importance. The almost identical Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky function primarily as comical figures. Their bumbling speech, overly sentimental well wishes, and overall triviality contribute to the play's comedy.



Scene 6. The Inspector of Schools starts to congratulate the mayor, but his wife interrupts him to congratulate Anna Andreyevna effusively.

When the Inspector of Schools comes to pay his respects to the mayor, he satisfies the mayor's desire for outside approval and praise. He also tries to maintain a positive image for himself. However, the fact that he's quickly interrupted by his loquacious wife further characterizes him as a nervous pushover. The humor of the Inspector of Schools being so timid emphasizes how ridiculous it is that he holds a position of authority as a town official.



Scene 7. The Chief of Police congratulates the mayor. Anna Andreyevna recounts Khlestakov's proposal as gentlemanly and beautiful, and she recalls compliments he supposedly gave her. The mayor's guests offer more well wishes to him; however, in asides, the Inspector of Schools, Warden of Charities, and the judge mock the mayor's aspirations of living in St. Petersburg as a general. Still, they ask the mayor to do them favors once he rises in rank.

Even though she's not the one engaged to Khlestakov, Anna Andreyevna seeks attention and praise for herself, demonstrating her pettiness, vanity, and selfishness. Also, by portraying Khlestakov as an exceedingly refined gentleman who admired her lavishly, Anna exposes her self-deception about Khlestakov's identity. Meanwhile, the town officials reveal that their obsequious regard for the mayor is fake. In reality, they're fully aware that the mayor's stupidity and corruption make him undeserving of the greatness to which he aspires. However, the officials still flatter the mayor and greedily demand favors from him, which testifies to their own corruption.



Scene 8. The postmaster rushes in and declares that Khlestakov isn't the government inspector at all. The postmaster has opened and read Khlestakov's letter, fearing that Khlestakov might have reported him to the authorities. In doing so, the postmaster discovered that Khlestakov is a nobody. For proof, the postmaster reads aloud the letter, which exposes Khlestakov's glee at being treated like royalty by fools, although each town official tries to stop the letter from being read when he hears an insult directed at him. Finally realizing their mistake, the distraught officials remember how much money they lost to Khlestakov.

Once again, the postmaster demonstrates his simple-mindedness, incompetence, and violation of duty. In this case, however, his corrupt ways help the town officials finally realize Khlestakov isn't a government inspector. They only convinced themselves that he was, and all their efforts to win him over were in vain. The officials' first impulse is to protect their own reputations from ridicule, which shows how self-centered and shallow they are. Concerned only with their images, the officials care more about appearing dignified in front of other people than about maintaining true dignity by fulfilling their duties properly. Moreover, the officials' second impulse—to lament the money they've lost to Khlestakov—demonstrates their selfish greed.



The mayor berates himself for being a fool, feeling like the whole world will know he's been duped. The mayor particularly dreads that a hack will put them all in a comedy. Furiously, the mayor exclaims, "What are you laughing at? You're laughing at yourselves, that's what!" Then the mayor reflects that Khlestakov never really seemed like a government inspector and demands to know who first claimed he was. The officials turn on Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky.

The mayor recognizes that he's deceived himself and has his own folly and vices to blame for his embarrassment. However, the mayor still isn't repentant for his crimes. Instead, he's most upset that he's being laughed at for his mistake. He craves external validation so much that he prioritizes looking good over being and doing good. By encouraging the audience to ridicule the foolish, corrupt mayor, the play satirizes people who try to preserve their positive images while shamelessly committing wrongdoings. At the same time, through the mayor, the play also holds a mirror to the audience, warning them that they might be just as foolish and corrupt as the characters on stage. In this way, the play critically references the flaws of 19th-century Russian society, including real political corruption and human greed, selfishness, and folly.



LAST SCENE AND MUTE SCENE

Last Scene. A gendarme announces that the real government inspector has arrived and demands the officials' presence immediately. Everyone freezes, struck intensely by these words.

The arrival of the real government inspector implies that the town officials won't get away with their corruption. Despite all their ridiculous efforts to conceal and preserve their crooked ways, the officials will likely get caught, as they deserve. Thus, the play ultimately condemns its immoral characters and their crimes. The officials' stupefied reactions to their ensnarement comedically showcase their foolishness and guilt.



Mute Scene. The entire, speechless group is transfixed like statues in various positions. In the center, the mayor stands with his arms outstretched and his head thrown back. His wife and daughter reach out for him. The postmaster is "transformed into a question mark," the Inspector of Schools appears bewildered, and the Warden of Charities tilts his head as if to listen to something. The judge crouches and seems about to whistle or speak. Korobkin winks at the audience and "directs contemptuous looks" toward the mayor. Bobchinsky and Dobchinsky reach for each other with wide eyes and gaping mouths.

The characters on stage create a tableau vivant, or a "living picture," by forming a silent and static scene. In this tableau, many of the characters' poses and expressions are ambiguous. However, the range of emotions on display is telling. The mayor seems to despair, which reflects his new awareness of his guilt and folly. The postmaster and Inspector of Schools especially seem shocked and confused, which emphasizes their lack of intelligence: they still don't understand their situation. Meanwhile, Korobkin silently bids the audience to deride and scorn the mayor, signaling that this response to the play's corrupt characters is appropriate. The concluding scene of The Government Inspector reinforces the play's satirical nature by encouraging the audience to laugh at and condemn the targets of its criticism.





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